Social Contract

Social contract is configured as an instrument of admission to the civil society. The ***Locke***an view proposes two contracts. The first one establishes the civil society and the second one calls for the constitution of government. He also recognises consent as the bedrock of the contract. To him, no individual can be admitted into this commonwealth without his/her own consent. ***Locke*** speaks of two kinds of consent: 1) formal or active consent, which is irrevocable in nature and 2) implied or tacit consent, which sanctions the departure of the stakeholders from the 'trust' and initiate a new order. ***Locke*** prefers the former as far as his version of contract is concerned, making it clear that there is no return to the state of nature. Another striking attribute of the ***Locke***'s contract is that individuals do not surrender their rights which they enjoyed in the state of nature. Submission of the rights would defeat the purpose of the contract itself as the state is being raised as the guarantor and protector of rights. Therefore, the contract is synonymous to a "charter of liberty" than a license for subjugation. The ***Locke*** an vision on social pact also authorises the option for revolution against a tyrannous system of governance. This measure is included in order to reaffirm the role of the state as the guardian of the natural rights of individuals. Furthermore, ***Locke*** leaves the decision on revolution to the legislature with a focus on the principle of majoritarianism and consent.

On the question of the nature of authority, he outlines the notion of limited-sovereignty. Absolute sovereignty is against his construct of civil society. ***Locke*** was also not hesitant to offer an alternative blueprint on the separation of powers. According to him, the powers of the government were separated among three organs. Firstly, the legislature, which he refers as the "supreme power of the commonwealth". Secondly, the executive, which also includes the judicial powers. Thirdly, the federative, which implies the power of external relations of a state. ***Locke*** was also tolerant towards the idea of a single-ruler which sanctions the concentration of all powers in one hand, provided that it is an outcome of the consent of the majority.

Quotable Quote

"Government has no other end, but the preservation of property". -***John Locke***

Assessment

John Locke, by virtue of his scientific temper and rationality, finds a significant place in the Western Political Thought. Being an individualist by conviction, he believed that humans are the makers of their own destiny. His works were a great source of impetus and inspiration for thinkers like ***Voltaire, Diderot*** and ***Rousseau***, and even for the French Revolution. According to ***Parrington, Locke***'s Two Treatises on Government "became the textbook of American Revolution". In the words of ***Prof. Laski,*** "***Hobbes*** worked with an impossible psychology and sought no more than the prescription against disorder. Burke wrote rather a textbook for the cautious administrator than a guide for the liberal statesman. But ***Locke*** saw that the main problem of the state is the conquest of freedom and it was for its definition in terms of individual good that he above all strove".

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